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Jesus Was Dead

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Jesus Was Dead

Today's Reading: John 19:31-37

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"When they came to Jesus and saw that he was already dead, they did not break his legs. But one of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and at once there came out blood and water."

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Pilate had agreed to take down the bodies of the crucified prisoners before nightfall. He instructed the guards to go and break their legs. This would cause death by asphyxiation. The broken legs would prevent the prisoners from pushing up on the cross with their legs so they could continue to breathe.

The two criminals on either side of Jesus had their legs broken because they were still alive. They died soon thereafter.

But when the guards came to Jesus, they saw that he was already dead, so they did not break his legs. However, to be completely sure, they took a long spear with an iron point and pierced it into his side. Blood and water poured forth. Through the ages, medical experts have looked upon this fact as evidence that Jesus was dead. Blood and water mingled together means a person is dead.

Why is this important? For centuries, preposterous theories have been proposed to dismiss the Lord's resurrection. One of them is called the "swoon theory." It suggests Jesus wasn't really dead on the cross. He was taken down alive and placed in a dark, dank, and damp tomb. There, his body was refreshed. He regained his strength and went to his disciples and convinced them he had risen. They then continued to carry out Jesus' ministry of hope and love to others.

Why is this theory preposterous? Think about all Jesus had experienced during his final hours. He'd gotten no sleep the night before. He received severe beatings. The 39 lashes on his back had been nicknamed "intermediate death" by the Romans because of the severity of this punishment. Some prisoners didn't survive it. He hung six hours on the cross—each moment taking him closer to asphyxiation. There was a spear stuck into his side.

Jesus was then taken down from the cross and placed in a tomb. After several hours, in the middle of the night, he was supposedly resuscitated. He then moved a huge stone weighing approximately one ton. He was then able to elude crack Roman guards and find his disciples, who were hiding in fear. He showed them his broken, bruised, and beaten body as a resurrection hope they needed to give the world.

It doesn't make sense. How could Jesus' bloodied and beaten body give them hope for their new and perfect resurrection body?

It also means they made up the story of Jesus being dead and then God raising him to new life. Why is this important? It suggests the disciples suffered persecution and martyrdom for what they knew was a lie. But people don't willingly die for what they know is a lie. They may die for what they think is true about God but isn't really true. But no one suffers and dies for what they know is a lie. It's against human nature. People are too self-protective. That's not how they operate.

Jesus was dead. The Roman guards, who were experienced at determining when people died, knew he was dead. It's why they didn't break his legs. It's why he was placed in a tomb.

People make up fanciful theories about Jesus for one reason: They don't want to yield their lives to him. They don't want to place moral reins on their life's lusts and passions. They want to be lord of their own lives.

Jesus had to be dead for the resurrection to be valid. He was crucified, died, and was buried. The "swoon theory" is frivolous. He was dead. The mixture of blood and water proves it. The early church placed this fact in their creedal statements (1 Corinthians 15:3-4). It's an essential bulwark of the Christian faith. It must be believed for the resurrection to make sense.

Jesus' death and resurrection has great significance for you. When you die, if you believe in him, you too will be raised to new life.

That means you can shout with confidence these words: "Hallelujah, Christ is risen!"

And you can also cry out, "Hallelujah, I am risen as well!"

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]